Already in 1899, as a young graduate student, Iqbal had caught the attention of the historian Sir Thomas Arnold, who was teaching at Government College, Lahore, at the time. Iqbal had received a gold medal in philosophy for reaching the highest grade in the final examination. In fairness, he was the only student taking the philosophy paper that year. Immediately after graduating, Iqbal was hired as a lecturer in economics. A recent graduate of Arabic and philosophy, Iqbal was an unusual appointment. But he made up for his lack of econometrics by writing an undergraduate textbook that approached the discipline from the broad lens of political economy, the *Ilm-ul-Iqtisad* – his first scholarly publication, and the first modern economics textbook in Urdu.[15] In this work, Iqbal keenly distinguished between the logic behind normative moral sciences, 'good and bad' and the logic of the marketplace, 'profitable and non-profitable'. He offered a balanced view of prevalent economic models at the turn of the century. After Arnold took up a fellowship at Trinity College, Cambridge, Iqbal swapped faculties and taught Arabic in Arnold's place for three years, a role for which he was much more suited.

A few years later, Arnold invited Iqbal to pursue further studies at Cambridge. Iqbal applied for leave from Punjab University and, aged twenty-eight, ventured on a steamship to Dover, where he docked in 1905. As an advanced student, Iqbal was not required to go through the rigours of tripos examinations. Instead, the academic labour of his stay was a short thesis on Persian metaphysics. Since Cambridge did not award doctorate degrees in 1907, Arnold advised Iqbal to hand in the same dissertation at Munich University to secure a PhD. Iqbal's first choice, Heidelberg University, had refused to accept a thesis written in English as they held the language unsuitable for academic pursuits and worried that it might dilute examination standards.

Had Iqbal returned to Trinity College in 1907 and not sailed back to Lahore after his brief stay in Germany, his relationship with Nehru may have turned out very differently. From mere distant but polite observers of each other's political gestures, the two may well have developed a friendship, whether over complaining about the unseasoned food in